ethically the right position'. Nehru emphasized 'the practical advantages to India of non-alignment and judged its efficacy on a pragmatic basis'. According to Gopal, non-alignment 'was firmly based on the current realities of the world'. Nehru often expounded the moral virtues of non-alignment, especially in later years, and reportedly annoyed other governments by appearing to demand a lot for India. Still, his policy reflected utilitarian advantage as much as idealism. 'It was not so much a code of conduct as a technique to be tested by results,' Gopal explained that Nehru did not consider it 'a wise policy to put all our eggs in one basket' and considered an honest and independent policy the best option 'from the point of view of opportunism'. [29]

Americans, in particular, objected to Nehru's non-alignment, terming it 'neutralism' and suggesting that it was not a moral position in a world threatened by the spread of communism. Escott Reid, who served as Canada's high commissioner to India (1952–57) did not agree with his American counterparts who considered Nehru's non-alignment as a heresy that benefited global communism. 'Mr Nehru is a man of very great intellectual ability, highly articulate and of great personal charm,' he wrote, adding, 'He is also, like other great men, sensitive and complex.' Reid argued that Americans 'should not only be conscious of Mr Nehru's difficulties but should also not expect him to behave as if he were a North American politician. It is important not to alienate Mr Nehru by treating his suggestions as second-class advice from a third-class friend. Democratic leadership in Asia can be developed only if the Western powers deal with Asian leaders as equals, seeking their counsel and occasionally deferring to their opinions.' [30]

Reid explained that by adopting non-alignment, Nehru was not tilting away from the Western powers, in favour of the Soviet Union and its communist allies. 'Nehru is, I submit, not neutral between our side and the USSR. He is a member of our side,' he insisted, pointing out that India as a